However, some military leaders felt the initial wave of repression was too harsh, and that the violence that followed was itself becoming a threat to the legitimacy of the military establishment. As a result, General Ne Win was removed from power. His successor, General Saw Maung, took over and initially carried on with the repression, subsequently claiming: 'the country has come back from the abyss, and I saved the country for the good of the people, according to law'.[36] However, he also sought to defuse the tensions by promising a return to democracy. Saw Maung was the first of the senior military leaders to rule Myanmar who had joined the army after independence. Over this series of transitions, the formal aspect of the regime ostensibly morphed from military to nominally civilian administration, but the reality was very much a case of the same establishment in charge. At each stage, the real goal was to retain control over Burma's wealth and the privileged status of the military.

Even so, the 1988 events had a significant impact and forced changes in the political structure of the country. First, the notionally socialist nature of the regime was changed with the adoption in 1989 of the name Union of Myanmar. And second, the ruling elite was forced into holding relatively free elections in 1990.

The 1988 events also saw the emergence of a new political movement—the National League for Democracy (NLD). This was created after the 1988 uprising, but its style of organisation and its political approach were based on well-established traditions in Burmese history.[37] From the 1920s, in opposition to both the British and Japanese, an important approach to politics was to combine illegal opposition (which by definition meant the actions of a minority) with a mass movement.[38] In the 1920s and 1930s this meant armed struggle, but the NLD's focus is on non-violent resistance. However, the concept of bringing together an elite model of politics and mass participation remains theoretically important to the NLD. The idea of mass resistance was important in the frequent street protests against the military which gave the leaders of the NLD a ready-made mass movement.

The NLD drew some of its legitimacy from its interpretation of the splits in the military in the period up to 1962, in particular about the role of the army in society. This coalition of interests with a part of the military was reflected in its initially appointing Brigadier General Aung Gyi as its chairman, former general Thura Tin Oo as its vice-chairman, and Aung San Suu Kyi.[39] Aung Gyi left after two months to form his own party, claiming